Rupani also tweeted a video titled ‘Madhav se Madhavpur’ (From Madhav to Madhavpur), in which breathtaking visuals of Hindu temples in Gujarat, like the legendary Somnath Temple, are intercut with old Hindu temples and places of worship in the Northeast. A voice-over says, ‘Gujarat and the Northeast region are separated by thousands of kilometres but have been relatives [sambandhis] for centuries … We will tell you a love story that centuries ago tied the two regions in a love bond [prem-bandhan]. This is a story of the Dwapar Yug, when a king of Gujarat did a love marriage with a princess of Arunachal … this is the story of the Lord of Dwarka Shri Krishna and Queen Rukmini.’ The video then cuts to a clip of Prime Minister Modi, wearing traditional Arunachal tribal headgear with hornbill feathers, speaking at a rally from a podium designed like a lotus: ‘Gujarat and Arunachal have a relationship that is thousands of years old,’ he says. ‘From Dwarka, Bhagwan Shri Krishna and our Arunachal Pradesh’s Rukmini, this is a relationship joining the East and the West, a relationship joining me and you.’[2] Having seamlessly connected the cultural past to the political present, the video transitions from religious imagery to Modi’s Look-East Policy (to cultivate links with Southeast Asia) and how the Northeast would be its central lever. It speaks of increased developmental funding through the DONER (Development of Northeast Region) ministry and moves on to images of smiling women from Arunachal who had received LPG cylinders under the Ujjwala scheme. It drew a straight line from what it called a relationship begun by ‘Gujarat’s bahurani [daughter-in-law]’ and the damaad (son-in-law) of the Northeast to the dream of #EkBharatShresthaBharat, a hashtag which trended that day on Twitter, with BJP ministers tweeting the messages and the prime minister retweeting them.[3]

This narrative of a primordial connection between the Northeast and the world of Hindu epics and legends is central to the message of cultural unity promoted by the BJP and the wider Sangh Parivar in India’s north-eastern states. Religious and mythological pasts speak of unity in diversity and a deeper cultural oneness as a central pillar of the BJP’s regional strategy. The Ram Janmabhoomi movement of the 1990s sought to break down divisions of caste and language to